Gypsum — a soft, naturally occurring mineral is used to alter colour of tea.

Vegetable oils - Edible oils are adulterated with mineral oil, karanja oil or castor oil. This causes loss of eyesight, damage to liver, heart problems, stomach infections or cancer Young children and senior citizens with poor immunity are more susceptible to this.



Plate 5.12 Vegetable Oils

Traditional sweets - Khoya and paneer are commonly used for the preparation of traditional sweets, and are often adulterated with starch. Silver coating (vark) used to decorate sweets is made from silver. According to Indian regulations, silver must be 99.9 per cent pure if it is used as a food ingredient. However, with silver becoming expensive many sweet shop owners use silver vark containing aluminium.



Plate 5.13 Traditional Sweets

Contamination of foods with harmful micro organisms

Some raw foods like meat, fish, milk and vegetables grown on sewage are likely to be contaminated with harmful microorganisms. These are generally destroyed during cooking or processing of food. Some of the micro organisms may survive due to inadequate heat processing. Even, low moisture foods when stored in humid atmosphere get infected with pathogenic fungus which causes serious illness.

Metallic contamination

Contamination of food with lead can cause toxic symptoms. Lead brings about pathological changes in the kidney, liver, and arteries. The common signs of lead poisoning are nausea, abdominal pain, anaemia, insomnia, muscular paralysis and brain damage. Fish caught from water contaminated with mercury salt contains large amount of mercury. The other elements which are toxic in small doses are cadmium, arsenic, antimony and cobalt.

Packaging hazards

Polyethylene, polyvinyl chloride and other allied compounds are used to produce flexible packaging material. While this method of packaging is very convenient, it must not contain any noxious thermal breakdown products which could be injurious to health. Further, temperatures used for sealing or sterilization should not result in formation of toxic residues. Therefore, it is essential to use food grade plastic packaging materials for packaging foods.

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